

Urethral Diverticulum

WARWIKI

Patient Information · A small pocket off the urethra that collects urine

A urethral diverticulum is a small **pocket** that forms off the urethra, the tube that carries urine out of the body. It is most common in women. Urine can collect in the pocket. This can lead to infections, dribbling, pain or a lump. It is often missed for years, but it can be treated.

About This Condition

Symptoms vary a lot, and some people have none. The most common are:

- **Urine infections** that keep coming back
- **Dribbling** of urine just after you finish, or other leaking
- A **tender lump** in the front wall of the vagina. Pressing it may push out urine or pus.
- Pain with sex, burning when you urinate, or pelvic pain

Because these symptoms look like other bladder problems, a diverticulum is often missed for years.

What Causes It

It is thought to start when small glands next to the urethra get **blocked and infected**. The infected gland bursts into the urethra and leaves a pocket that fills with urine. Past surgery or injury near the urethra may also play a part. It is not caused by anything you did.

A diverticulum is almost always **benign** (not cancer). Rarely, about 1–6 in 100, cancer is found in the pocket. This is why any removed pocket is checked in a lab.

Learn the Terms

Urethra

The tube that carries urine out of the body.

Diverticulum

A pocket that bulges out from a tube in the body.

MRI

A scan that shows the pocket's size and shape. It is the best test before surgery.

Diverticulectomy

Surgery to remove the pocket and repair the urethra.

Martius flap

A small pad of fatty tissue from the outer lip of the vagina, used to cover the repair.

Cystoscopy

A look inside the urethra and bladder with a thin camera.

Stress leakage

Leaking urine when you cough, sneeze or exercise.

Do I need surgery? Not always. A small pocket that causes few or no symptoms can be watched. If it causes infections, pain, leaking or a bothersome lump, surgery to remove it is the main treatment. A pocket that has stones, blood or a solid area needs a closer look first.

How It's Diagnosed

- A **pelvic exam** to feel for a tender lump along the urethra
- A urine test for infection
- An **MRI**, the best way to show the pocket before surgery. An ultrasound is sometimes used.
- Sometimes a **cystoscopy** to look for the opening from inside

How It's Treated

- 1 **Watching it** if the pocket is small and causes few or no symptoms. Infections are treated when they happen.
- 2 **Diverticulectomy:** surgery through the vagina removes the whole pocket and closes the urethra in layers. A Martius flap is sometimes added. A repeat surgery for a pocket that came back is harder, and the pocket returns more often.
- 3 A **catheter** stays in for about 10 to 21 days while the urethra heals. Your team then checks that you empty your bladder well.

Results of Surgery

7 in 10

are free of symptoms after surgery

2–10 in 100

have the pocket come back

1 in 8

have new stress leakage a year later; exercises often help

Numbers are averages from published studies. Your own risk may differ; ask your team.

Call the office that is treating you if you have:

- A temperature of **100.4 °F (38 °C)** or higher, or chills
- Pain, swelling or discharge that is getting worse
- Blood in the urine, or a lump that becomes hard

Go to an emergency department if:

- You **cannot urinate** for several hours, or your catheter stops draining and your bladder feels full
- Heavy bleeding from the vagina
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

1. A urethral diverticulum is a small pocket off the urethra. Repeat infections and a tender lump are common clues.
2. An MRI maps it best. Small pockets with few symptoms can be watched.
3. Surgery removes the pocket. Plan for a catheter for up to 3 weeks afterward.